

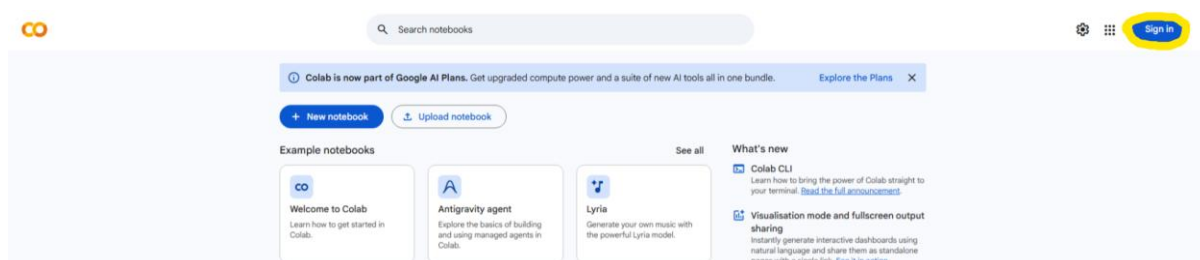
Getting Started with Google Colab

A step-by-step guide to registering using your institutional email

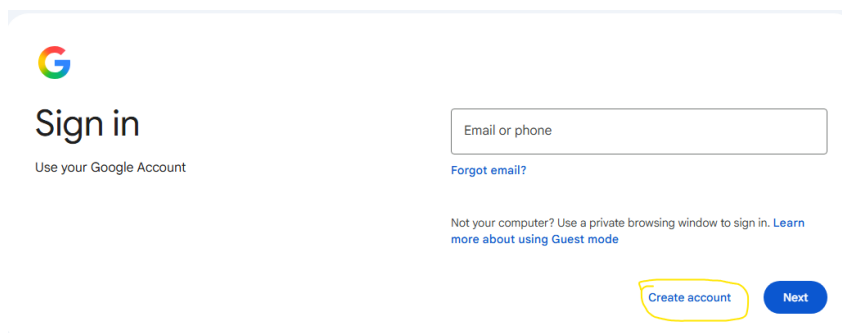
Google Colaboratory (“Colab”) is a free, browser-based notebook environment for writing and running Python code, widely used for data analysis, statistics and machine learning. Google Colab requires a Google Account, and you can create one using your LSE email. Alternatively, you can use your personal Google Account.

Step 1: Open Google Colab and Create a Google Account

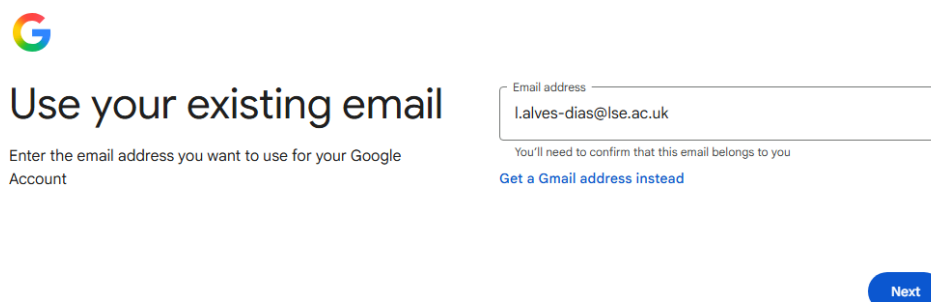
1. Open Google Colab by going to colab.research.google.com.
2. Colab should open directly to a welcome screen listing recent notebooks (empty if this is your first visit). Click on “Sign in” in the top-right corner of the screen.



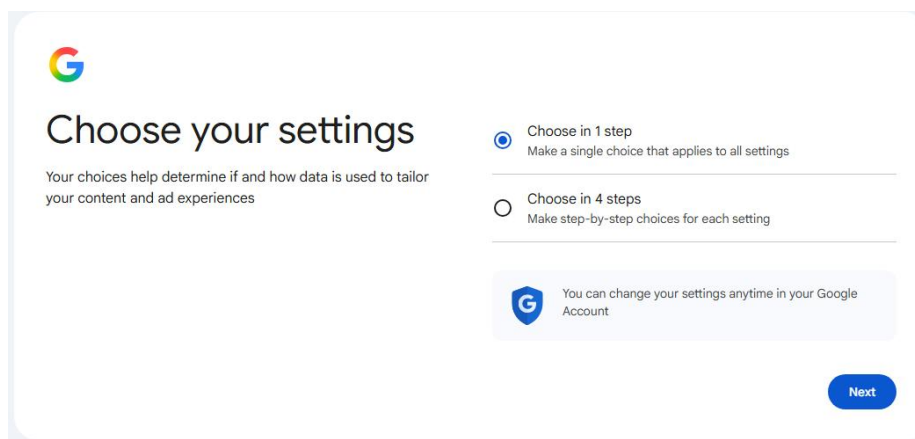
3. If you have a Google account, feel free to use it to login. Otherwise, create one. You can do this using your LSE Email. Click on “Create account” and choose “for my personal use”. Follow the steps by filling out the required fields.



4. When choosing your email address, you can click “use your existing email address” in order to use your LSE email.



5. Choose your settings as shown in the image below. Then press “Reject all” to reduce data collection for advertising purposes.



6. Press “Confirm” and “Agree” to the Terms and Conditions. You should now be logged in to Google Colab.



Step 2: Create your first notebook

1. From the Colab welcome screen, click “New notebook” (or use File → New notebook from the menu). Alternatively, you can click “Upload notebook” to use a Jupyter notebook from your local machine.
2. A new notebook opens with an empty code cell. Colab automatically saves it to a folder called “Colab Notebooks” inside your Google Drive.
3. Click the notebook’s title at the top of the page (default: “Untitled0.ipynb”) and rename it to something identifiable, e.g. “Week1_Intro.ipynb”.

Step 3: Run your first cell

1. Click into the empty code cell and type: `print("Hello, LSE")`
2. Run the cell by pressing Shift + Enter, or by clicking the play (▶) button to the left of the cell.
3. Output should appear directly below the cell. If you see the printed text, your setup is working correctly.

Step 4: Know where your work is saved

- Notebooks save automatically to Drive → Colab Notebooks in your Google Drive, not to your computer.
- To submit work or share with a tutor, use File → Download → Download .ipynb, or File → Save a copy in Drive to share a link, depending on what your course asks for.
- If a class or workshop hands out a shared notebook link, use File → Save a copy in Drive immediately — this creates your own editable copy rather than editing the original.

Step 5 (optional): Enable a free GPU

For machine learning tasks that benefit from GPU acceleration:

1. Go to Runtime → Change runtime type.
2. Under “Hardware accelerator”, select T4 GPU.
3. Click Save. Note that free GPU time is limited and shared, and may be restricted at busy periods (e.g. near assignment deadlines) — start GPU-based work early.

Troubleshooting institutional account issues

These are the most common problems LSE students hit with an institutional account, and how to resolve each:

Symptom	What to do
Repeated sign-in pop-ups or being asked to log in again and again	Usually a browser pop-up blocker or multiple signed-in Google accounts conflicting. Allow pop-ups for google.com, or open Colab in an incognito/private window signed in only to your LSE account.
Can view but cannot edit or save a shared class notebook	You are editing the original file. Use File → Save a copy in Drive to create your own version first.
GPU unavailable or runtime disconnects frequently	Free-tier GPU access is limited and shared across all users, and demand rises near deadlines. Save work frequently and start GPU-heavy tasks well ahead of time.